Pride and Prejudice: Context

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Pride and Prejudice historical context

The novel was published in 1813 and is set during the Regency period, a period marked by the reign of King George IV.

- King George III's mental illness led to the establishment of the Regency in 1811, with his son ruling as Prince Regent:
  - This period marked political instability and a shift in power dynamics within the monarchy
- Britain was involved in the Napoleonic Wars (1803–1815) against France, which impacted the economy, politics and society:
  - The militia was a critical part of British defence during this period
- During the Regency Period, aristocracy was not solely determined by noble lineage:
  - Instead, being accepted by the ruling class often hinged on demonstrating that wealth had been acquired in a gentlemanly manner

How this links to Pride and Prejudice	
The presence of the militia	The presence of the militia in Meryton reflects the ongoing Napoleonic Wars. Their arrival and interactions with the Bennet sisters creates social opportunities as well as potential threats, as seen in Lydia's elopement with Wickham.
Land ownership	The Bennet family's precarious financial situation and the entailment of Longbourn to Mr Collins reflect concerns about land ownership and inheritance laws during the Regency period.

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Pride and Prejudice social context

    - Austen signed her work as written "by a lady" or "from the writer of Sense and Sensibility", an earlier novel

- It was frowned upon for women to write novels at that time and she feared society's prejudice towards her
- Austen lived in the early 19th century, a **patriarchal** society, where women had limited rights:
    - Women did not have the right to own properties or businesses
    - Men had the power to make decisions
    - Women were not as educated in the same way as men; they were taught basic literacy skills, manners and etiquette, and how to run a household

- The novel effectively illustrates what life was like for women in rural England during the early 19th century:
    - Austen's female characters are depicted as financially dependent on male characters and their primary focus is the home, family and marriage

- From the first sentence of the novel, it is clear that a woman must secure a good future by marrying a wealthy husband in this historical context:
    - Marriage for women leads to respectability and financial security

How this links to Pride and Prejudice	
Primacy of marriage	Austen highlights how women with very little or no dowry were pressured to find husbands by using their youth, beauty or charm (Elizabeth and Jane). Charlotte Lucas chooses to accept Mr Collins' proposal because she fears she may have no other opportunities (due to her age and lack of beauty).
Subverting gender norms	Through the character of Elizabeth Bennet, Austen challenges the rigid gender roles in society. Elizabeth rejects Mr Collins' proposal because she does not love him and would rather risk the chance of not having financial security than accept him. By challenging the role and prospects that society grants her as a woman, she chooses her own destiny and finds greater happiness than other female characters.

Social class

- During the late 18th century (when the novel was written) and the early 19th century (when the novel was published), English society had distinct social classes based on social rank and wealth:
    - Characters are often judged based on their social standing and connections

- Jane Austen's social status was the same as the Bennets' status in the novel:

Help me understand

classes but were beneath them in wealth and consequence

How this links to Pride and Prejudice	
Attitudes of the upper class	Mr Darcy and Lady Catherine de Bourgh represent upper-class society — landed gentry and the **nobility** — and serve to highlight differences between the classes. Mr Darcy's wealth and social status make him an eligible bachelor but his pride and initial reluctance to engage with those of lower status contribute to the central conflict in the story.
Conforming to societal expectations	Austen uses characters like Mr Collins to highlight the absurdity of blind adherence to social classes and the desire to climb the social ladder. Characters such as Miss Bingley and Lady Catherine de Bourgh, who refuse to deviate from rigid social classes and expectations, end up isolated and alone at the novel's end.
Challenging societal norms	Characters like Elizabeth Bennet challenge the notion that worth should be solely determined by class and instead advocate for personal character and integrity. Through Elizabeth, Austen criticises the rigidity of social hierarchy and illustrates how, if classes were allowed to mix, it would lead to greater happiness and fulfilment.
	Mr Darcy also undergoes a development in his understanding of social class. Mr Darcy realises the importance of personal character and his subsequent efforts to overcome his own class-based biases contribute to the novel's resolution.

Pride and Prejudice literary context

Realism in 19th-century novels

- Realism is a literary genre that presents stories that are realistic, ordinary and deal with everyday life
- Jane Austen provides a realistic depiction of the social structures and hierarchies of her time:
  - The novel explores the lives of different social classes, from the gentry like the Bennet family to the nobility, represented by characters like Lady Catherine

intricately developed, contributing to a believable narrative

- Austen realistically portrays the courtship and marriage customs of 19th-century English society:
  - The characters' thoughts on financial stability, social status and compatibility in their pursuit of marriage reflect the realities of the time
- The writer incorporates realistic settings, such as rural England, the town of Meryton, and the estate of Pemberley:
  - These locations contribute to the novel's authenticity and provide a realistic backdrop

How this links to Pride and Prejudice	
Realism	Characters' discussions about dowries, inheritance and financial stability reflect the economic limits of Austen's era and the issues related to marriage and future security. The novel explores a range of moral dilemmas and choices faced by characters. Their struggles with pride, prejudice and personal growth contribute to a realistic portrayal of human nature and the complexities of relationships. Through the characters and their interactions, Austen explores the complexities of human behaviour.

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